

Jackson excelled in the Northern Virginia campaign of August 1862 that climaxed at Second Bull Run. His subsequent capture of Harpers Ferry through bombardment showed the skills of a former artillery officer. At Antietam and Fredericksburg he demonstrated his capacity for conducting a stubborn static defense in situations where maneuver was impossible. He always acted with an absolute disregard for personal safety, convinced that God would preserve him from harm until He chose the moment to strike him down. Jackson had no luxuries to ease the hardship of campaigning, often sleeping on the ground in all kinds of weather. He chose as his mount a plain, sturdy horse—Little Sorrel—rather than a fine charger. To see their commander simply dressed, sharing their hardships and risks, reconciled his soldiers to their lot.

In May 1863, Jackson marched most of Lee's army across the Union front for a devastating surprise flank attack at Chancellorsville. It was a supreme exhibition of his skill. When the day's fighting subsided, he led his staff on a reconnaissance beyond his own lines. As they rode back in moonlit darkness nervous Confederate soldiers, believing them to be Union cavalry, opened fire. Jackson was hit three times. As a result, his left arm was amputated, prompting Lee's heartfelt comment, "He has lost his left arm; but I have lost my right." Initially, it seemed that Jackson would recover, but he succumbed to an attack of pneumonia and died eight days later.